

Youth Ministry Lesson Plan: James 3:5-12

(45 minutes to 60 minute lesson plan)

Items you will need:

-Headbands (ribbon, yarn, even string will do – cut long enough so participants can gently tie headband around their head)

-Premade labels on note cards. Write in black marker labels associated with middle/high school students, such as: Popular, Loser, Jock, Geek, Friendly, Nerd, Teacher's Pet, Smart, Bully, Wimp, etc.

-Bibles

Lesson Plan

1. **Begin with sharing highs and lows of the week:** As group sits in a circle, invite each member to share one high and one low of the week. I use a stuffed “talking bear” during this time. Whoever has the “talking bear” gets to talk, and everyone else listens. Be sure that everyone knows they have the option to skip. I generally start with a volunteer and then have the talking bear passed along the circle to ensure that everyone has an opportunity. (10-15 minutes)
2. **The Activity:** Pass out the headbands and have everyone tie the headband comfortably around their head. When they are done, place a note card with a label between each person's headband and forehead. (Some members of the group maybe be very sensitive about specific labels. A label might be too personal for an individual. Use common sense judgment – it's probably a bad idea to give the label “loser” to someone who has been made to feel that way.) Make sure no one knows the identity that is on their note card. When everyone has a note card, invite them to stand up and, with their words, treat one another as if they are the identity of their note card. When they are done, invite them back into the circle. (10 minutes)
3. **Discussion:** Ask questions like: How did it feel to be labeled by someone else? How did the words that people spoke to you make you feel? What kind of power do our words have? (10 minutes)
4. **James 3:5-12:** Before they read say, “This passage talks about the power of the tongue. What might the phrase ‘power of the tongue’ refer to?” (You are looking for an answer about the power of words.) Then invite the group to open their Bibles and find James 3:5-12. Ask a volunteer to read and have others follow along. (I often have a volunteer start with one verse and have them go around the circle reading verse by verse. Of course, everyone has the opportunity to pass, but tends to ensure that everyone knows how to

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find a book in the Bible and that people are reading along.) (15-20 minutes, including questions below)

a) **Questions to ask:**

- i) What does this passage say about the power of our words?
- ii) One phrase in the passage is “With it [the tongue] we bless the Lord and Father and with it curse those who are made in the likeness of God. From the same mouth comes blessing and cursing. My brothers and sisters, this ought not to be so.”
 - (1) Ask: What might be the problem with using our words to bless God and curse our fellow human beings?
 - (2) Ask: Who is made in the likeness of God? Follow up that question by referring to the creation story in Genesis 1:27 – “God created humankind in God’s image.” When this passage was written, other cultures assumed only pharaohs and kings were created in the image of the gods. What does it mean that Genesis labels everyone as an image of God?
 - (3) Ask: James says that we ought not to use our words to bless God and curse our fellow human beings. How ought we to use our words?
 - (4) Concluding question: How would your school look different if we intentionally saw everyone as an image of God and intentionally used our words to bless that image? How would the world look different if we did that?